WAS JOB SELF-RIGHTEOUS?

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Was Job Self-Righteous?

I woke up one morning and while praying in bed the Holy Spirit spoke these words to me "God rebuked Job for being self-righteous".

This really got my attention because I had always thought of Job as being a righteous man and blameless in all he did. After all, even God said he was an upright man in Job 1:8. So what did God mean when He said this? We are going to find out.

When God spoke those words to me, I had such a desire to read through the book of Job from this perspective. That day I read the whole book of Job only taking a twenty minute break to eat lunch. The next day I spent five hours putting on paper what the Holy Spirit showed me the day before as I read the book of Job. I am not telling you this for you to pat me on the back. The reason I am telling you this is so that you will know that the Holy Spirit was guiding me.

At the time of Job, there was no Mosaic law. Job is the oldest book in the Bible. This is important to understand because in Ezekiel 14:14 it says that Noah, Daniel and Job were righteous. That was

true when Ezekiel was written because Ezekiel was written after the book of Job.

Before the Mosaic law was given, salvation was received, not earned, just like it is today.

Abraham **received** salvation **because he believed in God** and it was credited to him **as righteousness**. He was **made righteous** because he **believed** in God. **He received it as a free gift.** Not so with Job. Job was trying to earn his salvation by good works. Trying to earn righteousness and one's own salvation by good works is actually self-righteousness. **Self-righteousness does not save us**. It is our belief in God, without adding our good works, that saves us. However, when we truly believe, good works will automatically follow but not to earn our salvation. Our good works stem from our love for our Savior.

Christians can read the book of Job or hear teaching on the book of Job that he was a righteous man and yet all these bad things happened to him and they can become afraid it will happen to them as well. God wants to set us free from that fear today.

When I read the book of Job from the perspective that he was a self-righteous man, this book finally made sense to me. I could not understand it before when I read it from the perspective that Job was a righteous man.

Sometimes we have pre-conceived ideas because of what we have been taught in the past but God wants to remove those pre-conceived ideas so that we will have a right understanding of His Word.

So let's look at the book of Job to see what the Word actually says about Job.

Job 1:3b "He was the greatest man among all the people of the East."

Job had a great reputation among the people. Everyone looked up to him. Job was flawless in his **good deeds**. Job truly did want to do things right before God. He was reverent towards God and wanted to set a right example for others in his words, deeds and actions but he went about it the wrong way.

It is easy to do everything right when all things in your life are going well but all of a sudden

circumstances changed drastically in Job's life. His oxen and donkeys were carried off and his servants were killed. His sheep and servants were burned. His camels were carried off and servants killed and his sons and daughters all died, yet Job praised God. However, when he was afflicted with sores in his own body **what was in his heart became exposed**.

Let's find out what was in Job's heart from the Word.

He sat with his three friends and he began to question God. In Chapter 3 Job goes on and on questioning why God made him, saying it would be better had he not even been born. He concludes by saying in *Job 3:25 "**What I feared** has come upon me; **what I dreaded** has happened to me."*

So we see from this scripture that Job had a lot of fear and dread in his heart.

*1 John 4:18 "There is no fear in love. But perfect love drives out fear, because **fear has to do with punishment**. The one who fears is not made perfect in love."*

Job did not know God's perfect love for him. He was afraid of God's punishment if **he did** something wrong. He only knew God as One he had to please and serve. He thought he had to do everything perfectly in order to please God and be accepted and loved by him so **he made sure** that he was blameless and righteous in everything **he did**. He was **afraid** that if **he didn't do** everything right, God would be angry with him. Job was **fearful** that his children would do something wrong in God's eyes, so he presented sacrifices to God on behalf of his children to calm his own **fears**.

When we think we can **earn** God's approval, protection and blessings by our own efforts and **by what we do**, then when things go wrong, we think **God owes us** something for all our **good deeds**. When difficult times come our way, we begin to accuse God, blame Him and condemn Him for not rescuing us **because of all the righteous things we have done**. We feel that God owes us something. This is what Job did. I've done this myself at times. How about you?

In Chapter 4, Eliphaz, one of Job's friends, replied to him and told Job about a dream God gave him. Eliphaz had a dream and he heard a voice say: "**Can a mortal be more righteous than God? Can a man be more pure than his Maker?**"

Let's look at this scripture.

Job 4:12-17 "A word was secretly brought to me, my ears caught a whisper of it. Amid disquieting dreams in the night, when deep sleep falls on men, fear and trembling seized me and made all my bones shake. A spirit glided past my face, and the hair on my body stood on end. It stopped, but I could not tell what it was. A form stood before my eyes, and I heard a hushed voice. ***Can a mortal be more righteous than God? Can a man be more pure than his Maker?"***

This is Eliphaz' dream and he spoke these words to Job. These are pretty strong words spoken to Job. It sure sounds like self-righteousness and pride being exposed in Job's heart but Job does not see it. He justifies himself and while justifying himself he puts himself above God.

Job replies to Eliphaz.

Job 6:28-30 "But now be so kind as to ***look at me (drawing attention to himself)****. Would* ***I*** *lie to your face? Relent, do not be unjust; reconsider, for* ***my integrity*** *is at stake. Is there any wickedness on* ***my*** *lips? Can* ***my*** *mouth not discern malice?" (emphasis and parenthesis added).*

KJV says "my righteousness" instead of integrity.

Job is self-absorbed. It's all about Job and how good he is. He did not listen to the words that God gave to Eliphaz in a dream.

In Chapter 10 Job sets out his **complaints to God** and **questions God for His cruelty towards him**. In Job's own eyes he is innocent and not guilty of any sin.

*Job 10:2-7 "****I will say to God****: Do not condemn me, but tell me what charges you have against me. (God does tell Job what charges He has against him and we will get to that.) Does it please you to oppress me, to spurn the work of your hands, while you smile on the schemes of the wicked? Do you have eyes of flesh? Do you see as a mortal sees? Are your days like those of a mortal or your years like those of a man, that you must search out my faults*

and probe after my sin ***– though you know that I am not guilty*** *and that no one can rescue me from your hand?" (emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Job 10:13-15 "But this is what you (still speaking to God) concealed in your heart, and ***I know*** *that this was in your mind:* ***If I sinned, you would be watching me and would not let my offense go unpunished****. If I am guilty – woe to me! Even if I am innocent,* ***I cannot lift my head, for I am full of shame*** *and drowned in my affliction. If I hold my head high, you stalk me like a lion and again display your awesome power* ***against me****. You bring new witnesses* ***against me*** *and* ***increase your anger toward me****; your forces come* ***against me*** *wave upon wave" (emphasis and parenthesis added).*

Job said he **knew** what was hidden in God's heart and he knew what was in His mind. Imagine such pride that he knows what's in God's heart and mind. God's Word says that His thoughts are higher than our thoughts and his ways are higher than our ways and yet Job puts himself on equal ground with God by saying he knows what's in God's heart and mind. We see a lot of pride in Job's heart.

Job says *"Even if I am innocent, I cannot lift my head, for I am **full of shame** and drowned in my affliction"*. Job is full of shame because his reputation is ruined before the people. Pride brings humiliation to us. Pride causes us to think of ourselves more highly than we ought to and when circumstances happen, we are full of shame because our weaknesses and imperfections are exposed. We are no longer considered perfect and blameless in the eyes of others. Self-righteousness and pride want to hide our imperfections. It does not want others to see our humanism or our weaknesses. The apostle Paul boasts of his weaknesses because he knew that when he is weak, God is strong.

Job wanted to be proved right.

Job had a wrong perception of God in his heart which caused him to think that God was against him and angry with him. When we think we are righteous because of everything **we have done** and the blameless life **we have lived**, we can accuse God and be angry with Him for being unjust. After all, we deserve to be blessed of God because of our self-righteous acts (our good

deeds). Self-righteous people will blame, accuse and condemn God.

Job desires to speak to God and to argue his case with Him.

Job 13:3 "But I desire to speak to the Almighty and to argue my case with God."

Job 13:15-16 (Job says) "Though he slay me, yet will I hope in him; ***I will surely defend my ways to his face****.* ***Indeed this will turn out for my deliverance****, for no godless man would dare come before him!"*

Job is persistent that he is right before God and that he has a case to present to Him that will prove himself innocent and that these things that God is bringing against him are unjust. Job is thinking very highly of himself. He thinks he has a right to defend himself to God's face.

Job did believe in God but he only had a form of religion. He knew God to a certain degree but he only had head knowledge of God. He thought he knew God better than he actually did. He had some wrong perceptions of God and wrong

perceptions of himself. **Job did not curse God but he dishonored Him** with all his questioning, complaining and accusations against God that came from his prideful heart. He set himself up as equal to God and maybe even a little higher than God.

Job condemns his friends for their lack of comfort by saying in Job 16:5 that if it were them in his place that **he would** encourage them and comfort them to bring them relief. He was thinking of himself more highly than his friends. He was putting himself above his friends.

Isn't that true of us sometimes. I know I have done this myself and God has shown me not to do this. I would say things like: I would not do that or I would certainly keep my word, if someone had not kept their word to me. I was putting myself above others by saying those things which is pride.

In Job 16:7-14, Job accuses God for wearing him out, for devastating his entire household, for assailing him and tearing him down, for turning him over to evil men, for crushing him and making him a target. In the very next verses, he says he

has mourned with sackcloth and weeping yet at the same time he says **his hands are free from violence and his prayers are pure**.

Let's look at those verses.

Job 16:15-17 "I have sewed sackcloth over my skin and buried my brow in the dust. My face is red with weeping, deep shadows ring my eyes; ***yet my hands have been free of violence and my prayer is pure****."*

Job says he has repented in sackcloth and ashes but it wasn't because he had done anything wrong. It was his ruined reputation that caused him to put on sackcloth and bury his face in the dust.

In Chapter 19 Job talks to his friends.

Job 19:5-7 "If indeed you would exalt yourselves above me and use my humiliation against me, ***then know that God has wronged me*** *and drawn his net around me. Though I cry, I've been wronged! I get no response; though I call for help, there is no justice"*

Job says that God has wronged him and does not respond to him when he calls for help. Job goes on

and on in Chapter 19 about God's injustice towards him. Job is looking for pity. He is focused on himself and his own righteousness rather than on God and God's righteousness.

Job 19:23-24 "Oh, that my words were recorded, that they were written on a scroll, that they were inscribed with an iron tool on lead, or engraved in rock forever."

What pride! What self-righteousness! God's Word is written on a scroll and the 10 commandments were engraved in rock. Job is putting himself equal to God.

Job 19:21 "Have pity on me, my friends, have pity, for the hand of God has struck me".

In other words, he wanted his friends to side with him against God; that God was wrong and he was right.

Job was so focused on himself. He was not focused on God and who God is. Self-righteousness focuses on self. Pride focuses on self. Self-righteousness is believing in self. Humility focuses on God as we realize that in and of ourselves we

are not worthy or deserving of anything yet we trust God to give us what we don't deserve (that's grace) and to not give us what we do deserve (that's mercy). Job felt he was deserving of much better than what God had dealt him **because of all his righteous deeds and blameless lifestyle**. It was all about Job. When we walk in humility, it is no longer about ourselves but about Jesus and what He has done for us in His great and awesome act of love and grace.

God said that Job was an upright man.

*Job 2:3 "Then the Lord said to Satan, "Have you considered my servant Job? There is no one on earth like him; he is blameless and **upright**, a man who fears God and shuns evil."*

Job was blameless and upright **in all his deeds**. It was all about how **good** (how righteous) Job could be **in and of himself**. Job saw himself righteous and blameless because of his many good deeds. God knew that this is what Job thought about himself but God also knew what was really in Job's heart.

Let's look at Paul in the New Testament for a minute.

Phil 3:3-9 "For it is we who are the circumcision, we who worship by the Spirit of God, who glory in Christ Jesus, and who put no confidence in the flesh – though I myself have reasons for such confidence. If anyone else thinks he has reasons to put confidence in the flesh, I have more: circumcised on the eighth day, of the people of Israel, of the tribe of Benjamin, a Hebrew of Hebrews; in regard to the law, a Pharisee; as for zeal, persecuting the church; ***as for legalistic righteousness, faultless****. But whatever was to my profit I now consider loss for the sake of Christ. What is more, I consider everything a loss compared to the surpassing greatness of knowing Christ Jesus my Lord, for whose sake I have lost all things. I consider them rubbish,* ***that I may gain Christ and be found in him, not having a righteousness of my own that comes from the law, but that which is through faith in Christ – the righteousness that comes from God and is by faith.****"*

Paul, like Job, had to repent of his self-righteousness which he considered rubbish **that**

he may gain Christ and be found in him through faith. Christ had not yet died for our sins during Job's lifetime but grace through faith in God was still available to Job just like it was available to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. They received salvation by grace through faith in God (not through their righteous deeds). Job needed to do this as well.

Let's continue on with the Book of Job.

In the following scripture Job **makes his complaint to God.**

Job 21:4 "Is my complaint directed to man? Why should I not be impatient?"

He was being impatient with God. Have you ever been impatient with God? I have but now that I have embraced the grace of God by faith, I am much more patient.

In Job 21:7-33 he points out numerous injustices complaining to God that he lets the wicked go unpunished but yet the righteous He punishes.

In Chapter 23:3-9 Job is telling his friends that he is searching for God **but cannot find Him**. He is

searching for Him so that he can state his case before Him. Let's look at some of these verses.

*Job 23:3-7 "If only I knew where to find him; if only I could go to his dwelling**! I would state my case before him and fill my mouth with arguments.** I would find out what he would answer me, and consider what he would say. Would he oppose me with great power? **No**, he would not press charges against me. **There an upright man could present his case before him, and I would be delivered forever from my judge**."*

Why couldn't Job find God?

Psalm 24:3-4a "Who may ascend the hill of the Lord? Who may stand in his holy place? He who has clean hands and a pure heart."

Job's heart was not pure before God. We're going to see that he wasn't even saved, so his hands were not clean.

Job continues his complaint to God.

*Job 23:10-12 "But he knows the way that **I** take; when he has tested me, **I will come forth as gold**. **My** feet have closely followed his steps; **I** have kept*

to his way without turning aside. ***I*** *have not departed from the commands of his lips;* ***I*** *have treasured the words of his mouth more than my daily bread".*

In Job's eyes, this was true, but Job was using **his own righteousness** as a means to earn justice from God. This is all about Job. Job does not once exalt God in these scriptures. He exalts himself.

Job responds to his friend, Bildad.

*Job 27:5-6 "****I*** *will never admit you are in the right; till* ***I*** *die,* ***I*** *will not deny* ***my integrity****.* ***I*** *will maintain* ***my righteousness*** *and never let go of it;* ***my conscience*** *will not reproach* ***me*** *as long as* ***I*** *live."*

In Chapter 29:7-25 again Job exalts himself. In verse 20 he says *"****My glory*** *will remain fresh in me, the bow ever new in my hand."*

This sounds like Paul before He came to Christ. After he came to Christ, he counted his self-righteousness as dung. He realized that self-righteousness would never save him. He needed to believe in God who would credit his belief (just

like Abraham) as righteousness. Job only had head knowledge of God. He **only heard** about God but he did not know Him personally like Abraham did.

In Chapter 31:4-34 Job goes on and on exalting himself and pointing out how he does everything right.

Job 31:4-6 (he begins this self-exaltation with) "Does he not see my ways and count my every step? If I have walked in falsehood or my foot has hurried after deceit – let God weigh me in honest scales and ***he will know that I am blameless."***

Job 31:35 (he says) "Oh, that ***I*** *had someone to hear* ***me****! I sign now* ***my*** *defense – let the Almighty answer* ***me****; let* ***my*** *accuser (referring to God) put his indictment (exoneration, praise) in writing. Surely* ***I*** *would wear it on* ***my*** *shoulder,* ***I*** *would put it on like a crown.* ***I*** *would give him an account of* ***my*** *every step;* ***like a prince I*** *would approach him."*

Did you notice that these scriptures are all about Job?

Job felt he could approach God and give God an account of his every step (his every good deed) and that God would exonerate and praise him by putting a crown on his head for all the good things he had done and Job would walk among the people with his chest stuck out in pride and be honored by all men again. He would have something to boast about.

This marks the end of Job and his three friends controversial words.

Elihu begins to speak in Chapter 32. **Elihu is the only one that God does not rebuke**. **So we need to pay close attention to what he says**.

In verse 1 he begins by saying *"So these three men stopped answering Job,* ***because he was righteous in his own eyes"*** and then says in verse 2 that he became very angry with Job **for justifying himself rather than God**.

He also says in verse 3 that he was angry with the three friends because they had found no way to answer Job. They only showed him his error and condemned him.

The three friends saw Job's pride but instead of showing him how to turn from pride to God, they **condemned** him for his pride.

Elihu continues.

Job 32:8 "But it is the spirit in a man, ***the breath of the Almighty, that gives him understanding****."*

He was saying that the three friends did not receive understanding from God to pass onto Job. He says understanding comes only from God. The three friends were looking at the natural things that were happening and they were passing judgment **instead of seeking God for understanding to pass onto Job**.

Elihu continues.

Job 32:18 "For I am full of words, and ***the spirit within*** *me compels me."*

The Holy Spirit was compelling Elihu to speak. Elihu **acknowledges** that it is God who has given him understanding and the words to speak. Elihu was not speaking out of his own understanding like the three friends. He sought God before speaking to Job.

Elihu puts Job at rest by telling him in 33:7 that Job does not need to fear his words as they will not condemn him, like his three friends.

In the next scripture reference, Elihu quotes back to Job some words that Job had spoken.

*Job 33: 8-11 "But you (referring to Job) have said in my hearing – I heard the very words – "**I am pure and without sin; I am clean and free from guilt. Yet God has found fault with me; he considers me his enemy**. He fastens my feet in shackles; he keeps close watch on all my paths."*

I just want to mention here that when you read the Psalms written by David, you see David's heart. When he talks to God in all his troubles he pours out his heart to Him and after He has poured out his heart he praises and exalts God. David was a man after God's own heart. He truly believed in God and because of his belief in God, God made him righteous. David knew it was God's righteousness that was in him because he believed in God.

I would encourage you to read Psalm 18 and take note of how David exalts God and of how God

comes to his rescue. In verses 27 to 50 David continually exalts God. It isn't about David but all about God. Highlight in your Bible all the times David refers to God and how God was with him strengthening him, helping him, enabling him, training him, arming him for battle, delivering him, rescuing him, etc. Job does not do this.

In the very next verse, Elihu says:

Job 33:12 "But I tell you, in this you are not right for God is greater than man."

Elihu continues to **exalt God** before Job to turn his wrong thinking and believing around in Job 33:13-30. He gives examples of God turning man from his wrong believing and from pride **to preserve his soul from the pit**.

Elihu sets forth salvation in Chapter 33 to get Job to humble himself and turn away from his self-righteousness and pride, to God.

Let's look at these verses.

Job 33:23-28 (Elihu speaking) "Yet if there is an angel on his side as a mediator, one out of a thousand, to tell a man what is right for him, to be

gracious *to him and say,* ***Spare him from going down to the pit****, I have found a* ***ransom*** *for him (Jesus is our Ransom) – then his flesh is renewed like a child's; it is restored as in the days of his youth.* ***He prays to God and finds favor*** *with him (grace),* ***he sees God's face*** *and shouts for joy;* ***he is restored by God to his righteous state****. (KJV says "He (God) will render onto man His righteousness.) Then he comes to men and says,* ***'I sinned, and perverted what was right, but I did not get what I deserved (mercy). He redeemed my soul from going down in the pit, and I will live to enjoy the light'****."*

Elihu confronts Job's self-exaltation, self-righteousness and pride **by not condemning him** but telling him about God and His salvation; that God is a gracious God and He ransoms us out of the pit and restores us to Himself when we humble ourselves before Him and receive his favor (grace). When we see God's grace, we recognize that we are sinners in need of a Savior. We repent of our self-righteousness and pride and we are free to walk humbly before our God and enjoy fellowship with Him. **Job did not have fellowship with God. He revered Him and he**

did what was right in His eyes, but he did not have an intimate relationship with God. Job only knew God as One he needed to please.

Elihu says to Job.

Job 34:33 "Should God then reward you on your terms, ***when you refuse to repent****?"*

Elihu was telling Job that he needed to repent of his self-righteousness and pride and receive God's grace.

Elihu continues to refute Job's words when Job says: *"where are you God, let me see your face so that I may present my case"*. Elihu's response to such words are found in the following scripture reference.

Job 35:12-16 "He does not answer when men cry out ***because of the arrogance of the wicked****. Indeed, God does not listen to their* ***empty*** *plea; the Almighty pays no attention to it.* ***How much less, then****, will he listen when you say that you do not see him, that your case is before him and you must wait for him, and further, that his anger never punishes and he does not take the least notice of wickedness.*

*So Job opens his mouth with **empty** talk; without knowledge he multiplies words."*

Job accused God of not punishing the wicked and yet He was punishing him who is righteous, according to how Job saw himself. Elihu says that God is not answering Job because of his arrogance. In fact, he refers to Job as wicked. Whenever the Bible refers to someone who is wicked, it is always referring to the unbeliever. Elihu was telling Job that he was not saved.

Elihu continues to exalt God and speak on God's behalf in Chapters 34-37 to turn Job's thinking around.

I just want to mention here that Elihu is like someone living under the **New Covenant grace** who will seek the Lord on behalf of others to get **God's mind** and to show them Jesus; not condemning them but not covering up their sin either.

On the other hand, Job's three friends are like those still living under the Old Covenant law of Moses and bringing condemnation to people

rather than seeking the mind of the Lord in how to help them and how to extend God's grace to them.

Then in Chapters 38-39 God speaks to Job and asks Job if he can do all the things that He does and if Job has the understanding that He does.

The Lord answers Job out of the storm. He begins by saying in *Job 38:2-3 "**Who is this that darkens my counsel with words without knowledge? Brace yourself like a man; I will question you, and you shall answer me**."*

So God questions Job and then waits for an answer from Job.

*Job 40:1-2 "The Lord said to Job: "Will the one who contends (argues) with the Almighty **correct him**? Let him who **accuses God** answer him!"*

Job is speechless as he has no words to speak to God in his defense but he finally says in *Job 40:4-5 "I am unworthy—how can I reply to you? I put my hand over my mouth. I spoke once, but I have no answer – twice, but I will say no more."*

Job is beginning to see that he was wrong **but still did not repent**. He only saw **his unworthiness**

before God, so God continues. God says in *Job 40:8-14 "Would you discredit my justice?* ***Would you condemn me to justify yourself****? Do you have an arm like God's, and can your voice thunder like his? Then adorn* ***yourself with glory*** *and splendor, and clothe* ***yourself*** *in honor and majesty. Unleash the fury of your wrath, look at every proud man and bring him low, look at every proud man and humble him, crush the wicked where they stand. Bury them all in the dust together; shroud their faces in the grave.* ***Then I myself will admit to you that your own right hand can save you.****"*

God is saying that Job was not saved; that Job's own righteousness could not save him. Only God could save him. In all this, God was pouring His love out to Job by confronting him.

Job thought that his own righteousness could save him but God was letting Job know that his own righteousness could not save him. God was exposing what was in Job's heart: self-righteousness and pride. They go hand in hand. He did this because He loved him.

God goes to great lengths in Chapter 41 to talk about the Leviathan. He begins by saying: "*Can*

you pull in the Leviathan with a fishhook or tie down his tongue with a rope". In other words, He was letting Job know that He could do these things but Job could not. The last thing God says to Job in *Job 41:33-34 "**Nothing on earth is his equal** (referring to the Leviathan)–a creature without fear. He looks down on all that are **haughty**; he is king over all that are **proud**."*

God is saying that the Leviathan was the greatest creature **on earth** and that He could pull in the greatest creature on earth with a fishhook but Job couldn't. In other words, there was no one who is equal to God.

God disciplines those He loves so God was telling Job that he was not equal to Him, that Job needed to humble himself and repent of his pride and self-righteousness and he needed to receive God's grace which is free and cannot be earned. He was telling Job that it was not his self-righteousness that would save him but God's righteousness which is freely given to all who believe in Him and have a relationship with Him.

In Chapter 42 Job answers God. He humbles himself before God. He finally sees what God is

saying to him. He finally sees his self-righteousness.

Job 42:2-6 "I know that you can do all things; no plan of yours can be thwarted. You asked, 'Who is this that obscures my counsel without knowledge?' Surely I spoke of things I did not understand, things too wonderful for me to know. You said 'Listen now, and I will speak; I will question you, and you shall answer me.' ***My ears had heard of you but now my eyes have seen you (the eyes of his heart)****. Therefore* ***I despise myself*** *and* ***repent*** *in dust and ashes."*

Job finally got it. He finally saw his self-righteousness and arrogant pride and repented. He realized that he had spoken of things that he did not understand. He admits to God that He had only **heard** about Him and that his knowledge of God was only head knowledge; that he did not know Him intimately. He only **heard** of God but now **sees** God for who He really is. **God!** He now **sees** God above him and greater than him. Now that Job **sees** God for who He really is, he humbles himself before God, repents of his self-righteousness and prideful words (which he now

despises) and receives God's righteousness. **It is no longer about his righteousness and all the good deeds he had done but about God and His righteousness.** Job moved from head knowledge (religion) to heart faith in God. The **eyes of his heart** were opened and he saw the condition of his heart. He enters into an intimate personal relationship with God.

After Job repents, God speaks to Job's friend, Eliphaz, in verse 7 and tells him that He is angry with him and his two friends because they did not speak of Him what is right, as His servant Job did.

Job 42:7 "After the Lord had said these things to Job, he said to Eliphaz the Temanite, "I am angry with you and your two friends, because you have not spoken of me what is right, ***as my servant Job has****."*

I was shocked when I read this because Job had not talked right about God. However, the Holy Spirit said to me that when we repent, the former things are no longer remembered by God. He forgets our sins and remembers them no more. **Since Job repented of trying to save himself, God did not remember all the accusations Job**

made against Him. What an awesome God! What a great redemption we have in Jesus Christ! When we turn from rejecting God, laying down our pride and self-righteousness and humble ourselves to receive His grace and His gift of righteousness by faith, we are saved and God remembers our sins no more (Hebrews 8:12 and also in 10:17). We are now the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. We are in right standing with Him. This is our new identity (position) in Christ Jesus.

I would like to mention here about a family in the bible who were devout, God fearing and generous just like Job. It was Cornelius and all his family (see Acts 10:1-2) but they were not saved. You can read Acts 10:1-18. God sent Peter to this family to tell them about Jesus so that they could be saved. Acts 11:14 says "He will bring you a message through which you and all your household will be saved". Even though Cornelius and his household were devout, God-fearing and generous, it was necessary for God to send Peter to them to bring the message of salvation that they responded to. Cornelius and his family humbled

themselves before God and received the free gift of salvation that Peter presented to them.

After Job came to the Lord by receiving God's righteousness (acknowledging that it wasn't his own righteousness that saved him but God's righteousness), God restored onto Job twice as much as he had before. Just as Job received a double portion blessing when he recognized his self-righteousness, repented of it and received God's righteousness, we too will receive a double portion blessing when we come out from living under the law, which is self-righteousness, and live under grace where we receive and embrace Jesus' righteousness.

We can decide that we are not going to be self-righteous anymore. I did this many years ago but it wasn't enough. We can choose not to be self-righteous **but this is not enough**.

In order not to be self-righteous, **we must embrace and receive the free gift of righteousness that Jesus gives us**. When we truly repent of self-righteousness, we are turning away from self-righteousness **and embracing Jesus' righteousness**. Repentance is an action.

Receiving Jesus' righteousness has nothing to do with our behavior. It has everything to do with our identity. This is who we are in Christ.

So let's take a few minutes to look at righteousness under the New Covenant of grace.

We are not made righteous because we do right. The book of Job tells us that. So, how are we made righteous?

When Jesus died on the cross He took all of our sins and He gave us His very own righteousness as a free gift. There was a divine exchange that took place. Because of this divine exchange, we are now the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. This is our new identity as a believer. This is who we now are. We are in right standing with God even when we don't do everything right. It is not our right behavior that saves us, just like Job was not saved by his behavior. It is our right believing that saves us. However, when we truly **believe** that we are right with God based on His righteousness and not our own, we will have corresponding actions. We will automatically produce acts of righteousness. These acts of righteousness may take some time to spring forth but stay in the

Word, getting your mind renewed with God's Word and you will see the results of believing right.

Do you see just how important this is for us to understand?

Sometimes in the Church we can be walking in a level of self-righteousness and pride even though we are saved. God does not want us to condemn ourselves for walking in self-righteousness but He does want us to understand what we are doing. Just like Job, we need to repent of our self-righteousness. I walked in a level of self-righteousness for years as a Christian because I didn't fully understand the grace of God. Even though I received Jesus into my life as my personal Savior and Lord by grace through faith, I went right back under the law to earn God's love, acceptance, approval and blessings through self-righteousness (through good deeds). Isn't that what Job was doing? I thought I had to do something to earn God's love, acceptance, approval and blessings when, in fact, all I needed to do is **believe** that God loves me, accepts me, approves of me and blesses me because I am His

child **and receive his free gift of righteousness**. We are walking in self-righteousness (just like Job) when we think it is our good deeds that saves us and makes us righteous. Sometimes as believers we think that we have to become more righteous or develop righteousness in our lives by trying to do everything right in God's eyes. This is self-righteousness. We still think that we have to earn salvation by our right living when, in fact, salvation is a free gift and cannot be earned. When we believe in Jesus, He gives us His very own righteousness as a gift. He makes us righteous and we receive His righteousness by faith, not by what we do. It is all about Jesus. It has nothing to do with us except that we believe in Him as our personal Savior and Lord.

We need to grasp that we are made righteous because of what Jesus did for us, not because of **what we do**. Job thought he was righteous because of his many good deeds. God wants us to continue to do good works but not to earn our salvation or His love and acceptance or even His blessings. We are loved unconditionally by God and accepted by Him simply because we believe in Jesus Christ as our personal Savior and Lord. We

are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. We need to believe this and when we believe this, good works will automatically flow from our right believing. In this situation, the donkey is in front of the cart pulling the cart. Job put the cart before the donkey thinking that it was all his good deeds that would save him. When we believe right, we will walk in Christ's righteousness and not our own. Righteousness is a free gift from Jesus to us the moment we believe in Him.

Ephesians 2:8-9 "For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith – and this **not from yourselves**, it is the **gift of God – not by works**, so that no one can boast."

When we walk in self-righteousness, we will boast of our good works just like Job did. Grace is a free gift just like righteousness is a free gift. Grace and righteousness go hand in hand. Romans 5:17b tells us to receive His abundant provision of grace and His gift of righteousness and we will reign in life through Jesus Christ.

Ephesians 6:14 tells us to put on the breastplate of righteousness. Our righteousness in Jesus is part of our armor. Are you wearing the breastplate of

righteousness? It will protect your heart from the condemnation of the enemy? Are you being protected by this piece of the armor?

When we walk under the law, we will walk in self-righteousness and pride but when we walk in the grace of God, we will walk in Christ's righteousness and humility.

When we walk in self-righteousness, we think we have the breastplate of righteousness on but we really we don't. When we believe that we are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus even when we don't do everything right, we have this piece of the armor firmly in place and our hearts are protected from the attacks of the enemy.

Believing with our heart that we are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus is a **weapon** that we use against the enemy when he tries to bring condemnation. Did you hear that? Paul says in 2 Corinthians 6:7 that he had **weapons of righteousness** in his right hand and in the left. Let's look at this scripture.

2 Corinthians 6:7 (Amplified) "By [speaking] the word of truth, in the power of God, with the

weapons of righteousness for the right hand [to attack] and for the left hand [to defend]."

He had the **weapons** of righteousness in both his hands. He was wielding the truth that he is the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus as a **double**-edged sword in both his hands. We need to have the weapons of righteousness in both our hands as well. Did you notice that the word "weapons" is pluralized? This weapon is two-fold. It is used to attack our enemy and to defend ourselves. Righteousness is a weapon we use against the enemy of our soul **and** to declare who we are in Christ Jesus. Knowing and truly believing that we are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus will set us free from sin. It is our right believing that will set us free! If you are struggling with sin, get your believing right and your actions will follow your right believing.

Did you know that the Bible says we are still immature Christians until we come to know that we are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus?

Hebrews 5:12-14 "In fact, though by this time you ought to be teachers, you need someone to teach you the elementary truths of God's word all over

again. You need milk, not solid food! Anyone who lives on milk, ***being still an infant****, is not acquainted with the teaching about* ***righteousness****. But solid food is for the mature, who by constant use have trained themselves to distinguish good from evil."*

Paul is saying that maturity is grasping the elementary truths of God's Word **and the teaching on righteousness.**

In Hebrews 6:1-4 Paul talks about the elementary teachings that every believer needs to know, believe and understand in order to go onto maturity.

*1 Corinthians 3:1-4 "Brothers, I could not address you as spiritual but as worldly – mere infants in Christ. I gave you milk, not solid food, for you were not yet ready for it. Indeed, you are still not ready. You are still worldly (they were worldly in their thinking and believing). (How?) For since there is jealousy and quarreling among you, are you not worldly? Are you not acting like mere men (****who don't know who they are****)? For when one says, "I follow Paul," and another, "I follow Apollos", are you not mere men?" (emphasis added)*

If we are still quarreling and jealous of others, we are not yet mature. We are not yet fully walking in our new identity. If we were walking fully in our new identity, we would be free from these things.

This message is not to condemn us but to challenge us to get our believing right and to walk in our new identity: that we are the righteousness of God in Christ Jesus. When we truly believe this, things like jealous and quarreling, wanting our own way and wanting to be recognized will fall away from us. It simply won't matter anymore because we know who we are in Christ Jesus.

Ask God to show you if you are walking in any self-righteousness and ask Him to help you walk in your new identity. I do this myself because I don't want to unknowingly slip back under the law and into unbelief, self-righteousness and pride. When God shows me it is not for me to condemn myself but to repent and ask for His help to turn from my wrong believing to right believing.

I trust that you now have a better understanding of the book of Job and that you will repent of any self-righteousness and pride that perhaps you are walking in, even as a believer. I pray that you will

embrace Jesus' righteousness which is a free gift and walk in His righteousness alone, not mixing it with your righteousness.